could be ordered in advance, and it generally was served later than planned, because it was rare for the trains to adhere to scheduled timings. On one particular day, we were provided dinner after midnight! However, mother had packed enough homemade food and snacks to keep the insatiable hunger of her four brats under control. We used to make tea in a unique manner. Mom had carried a big thermos, tea leaves, milk powder and sugar. When the train halted at a station, she would ask one of us, the older siblings, to walk up to the engine and fill up the thermos with hot water released from the boiler. The engine drivers would never say no to us. Tea brewed from this water, courtesy the railways, tasted quite nice!

The train journeys were always eventful. However, either all or one of us Marwah brats would land up in some mess or the other during the days immediately preceding the posting of our father. On one occasion, at a farewell lunch, we tried to bring down a huge beehive hanging from a tree in the host's garden. We did succeed, but paid a heavy price for this silly act. We were attacked by so many bees that all of us had swollen faces like sumo wrestlers, and had to be under medication for quite a few days. The next time around, it was I who was bitten by the foul-tempered and moody Alsatian dog of our neighbour. He seemed to have taken a dislike for me and was perhaps angry about having been given a cold water bath by the servant. It tore into my leg just a day before we were to leave on our train journey. During the voyage, a doctor from the railways would come as per schedule and give me the anti-rabies shot. In my opinion, the Indian Railways has always been a most disciplined, efficient and professional organization, developed by the British on the lines of the army. Consequently, like the army, the railways has also played a major role in integrating our country and in nation-building.

At the end of 1956, my father was posted to Jammu. We joined St Mary's Presentation Convent, a well-established English-medium school. After two uneventful years, in 1958, when I was in my final year of middle school, I was forced to change my school. This was because the Mother Superior was visiting from Ireland, and the